



INVISIBLE INFRASTRUCTURE

Mapping Care, Disconnection & Opportunity in L.A.'s Housing Crisis



OVER 75,000 PEOPLE IN LOS ANGELES
COUNTY EXPERIENCE HOMELESSNESS
ON ANY GIVEN NIGHT.

ARCHEOLOGY HISTORY OF HOMELESS & HOUSING IN AMERICA

(Olivet et al., 2019)

258 years of
Displacement, Enslavement

1607–1830:
Origins of Displacement
Colonization, land theft, Removal of Indigenous people

1619–1865:
Enslavement Era
Generational housing exclusion for Black Americans

120 years of
Urban Bias

1820–1940:

Urban Bias
Poorhouses, redlining, radicalized
planning

30 years of
Failed Governance

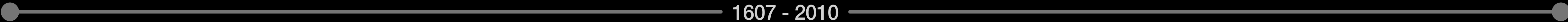
1960–1990:

Systemic Failure
Deinstitutionalization and housing
disinvestment

10 years of
Trying to think Bigger

2000–2010:

Awareness & Research
Equity enters
homelessness discourse



ENGRAINED LINEAGE OF DISPLACEMENT

- Colonization & De-naturalization
- Enslavement & De-humanization
- Exclusion for African Americans, Immigrants, People of Color

HISTORICAL ENFORCEMENT OF BIAS

- Redlining
- Redevelopment
- Criminalization

A HEAVY EMOTIONAL INHERITANCE

- Mistrust
- Instability
- Disconnection

PARADOX WHAT MAKES THIS PROBLEM SO HARD?

THE PARADOX

Efficiency ≠ Care + Community

Institutional care is abundant.
Relational care is scarce.

ARCHEOLOGICAL INSIGHT

Over the last 400 years, people of color, indigenous communities and immigrants have historically and disproportionately been affected by homelessness.

The efficiency-induced housing crisis has been at odds of the concept of what it means to have a place to call home. The real crisis is disconnection.

Exclusionary systems of a “housing-first model,” and “harm reduction,” has polarized the unhoused community’s basic desires to feel safe, clean, feed themselves and their children, and retain a sense of dignity and purpose.

PLURIVERSAL FRAMING

Astronauts have been known to experience a state of awe and unity when viewing Earth from space. They describe it as the overview effect, a cognitive shift to **see all people and systems as one.**

What if housing justice required the same planetary empathy?

What if the idea of a home wasn’t equal to square footage, but by deeper belonging, collective cultural resilience and care?

CURRENT CHALLENGES

More shelters	→	More opposition
More policing	→	Less safety
More services	→	More silos
Redevelopment	→	Displacement

FROM		TO
Efficiency	→	Connection
Housing as Commodity	→	Housing as Collective right
Data-driven Knowledge	→	Embodied Knowledge
Expert-led Leadership	→	Lived-experience Shared governance
Success measured by units built	→	Success measured by belonging and collective resilience

CONTEXT PLURIVERSAL STAKEHOLDER MAP

THE INSIGHT

Care pathways are mostly top-down and one-way

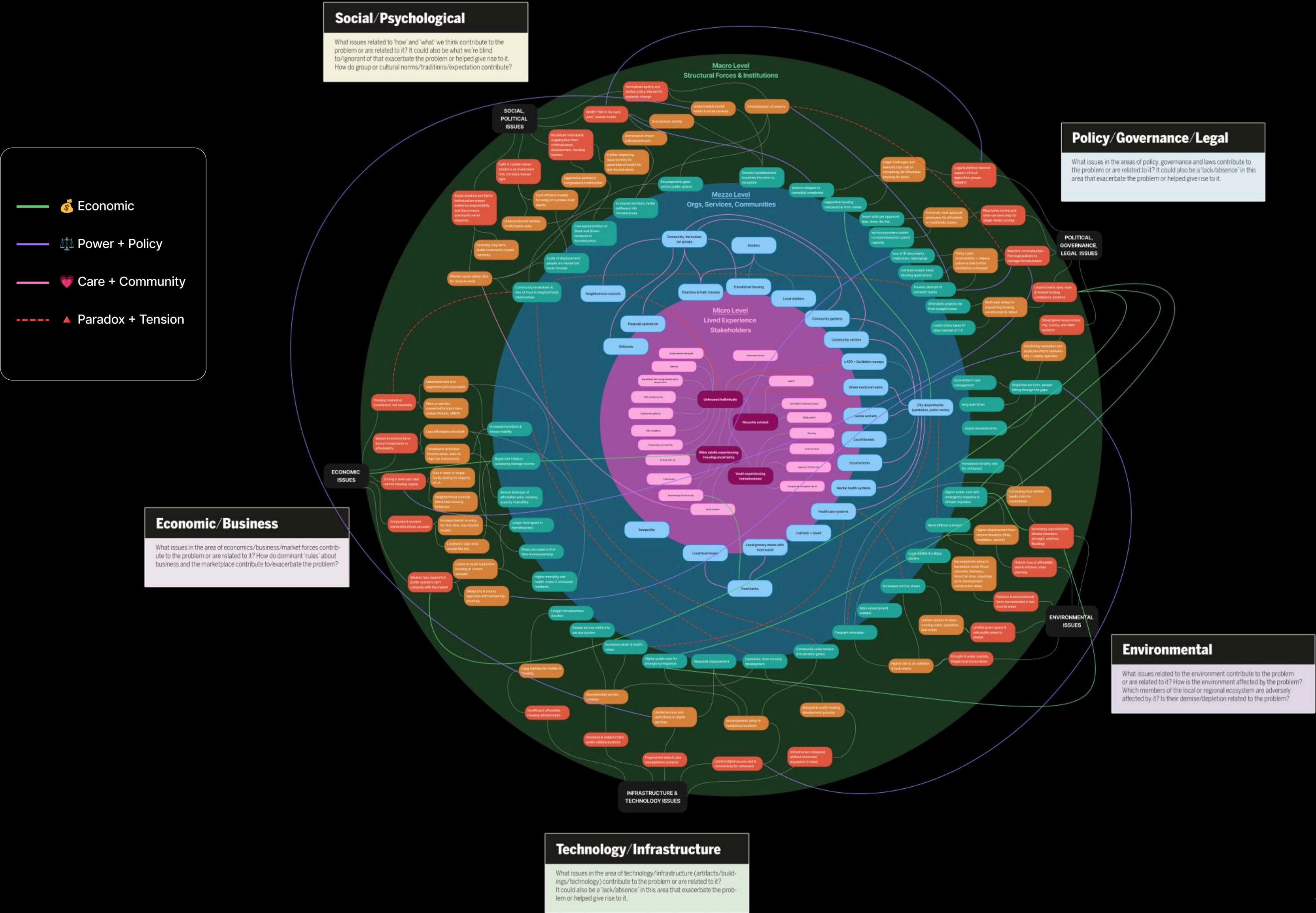
- Power + Policy as the main support system
- Economic + Business forces exacerbate an underfunded & outdated public system

Care rarely flows across, in, or out of communities

- Perpetuating apathy and political tension for the unhoused
- Care + Community pathways are minimized

Older adults receive the least relational care

- Fixed income
- Social isolation
- Food insecurity
- Rising medical & health needs



CULTURAL LENS RELATIONAL CARE

JEONG

This tradition represents the spirit of “jeong,” a Korean concept of deep emotional bond and affection.

It can be seen in acts of kindness, selflessness, and a desire to help others without expecting anything in return. It is often described as an invisible thread that ties people together.

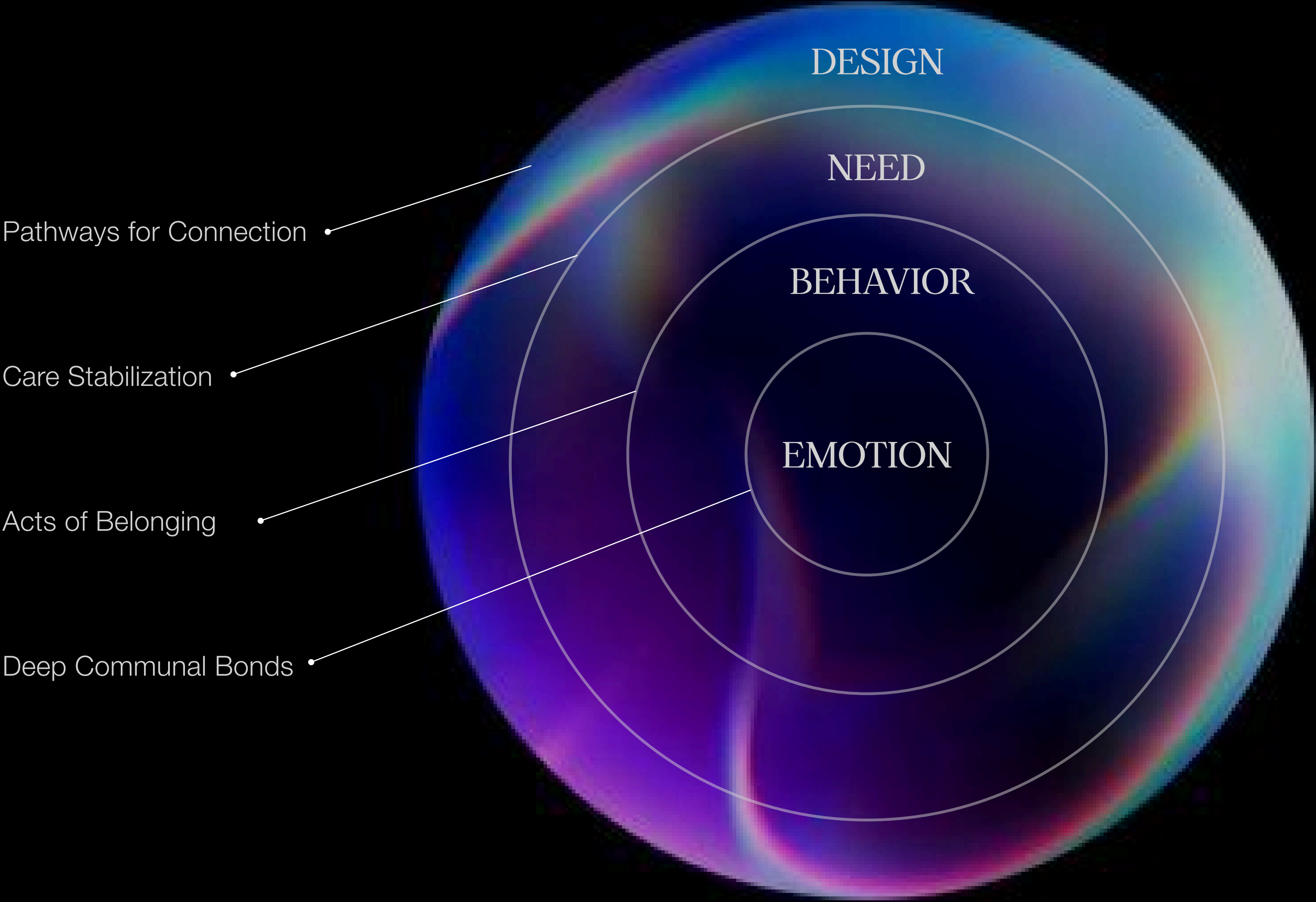
It develops slowly through relational, reciprocal care. It can be seen in everyday interactions, such as helping a stranger or sharing with a neighbor.



PROBLEM FRAME RELATIONAL INFRASTRUCTURE

PROBLEM STATEMENT

The crisis isn't only a lack of housing. It's a lack of relational infrastructure that supports belonging, reciprocity, and care. Especially for older adults living in uncertainty.



TYPE + MODE RECOMBINATION

TYPES OF UNHOUSED INDIVIDUALS	MODES OF NAVIGATING HOMELESSNESS	RECOMBINATION INSIGHT
Older Adults in Housing Uncertainty or Instability	Survival Through Disconnection • withdrawing socially • avoiding services due to shame, mistrust • unstable routines	Needs: belonging, continuity, relational safety Opportunity: A small, stable community space that fosters trust and slow relational growth
Unhoused Families	Crisis-Driven Adaptation • rapid decision-making • navigating multiple systems • prioritizing children’s safety	Needs: dependable support, predictable access Opportunity: Family-focused community rhythms (meals, after-school recreation time)
Unaccompanied Youth	Transient Mobility • couch surfing • moving through public spaces • maintaining autonomy	Needs: non-judgmental belonging, identity safety Opportunity: Youth-led creative or relational micro-rituals for safe expression
Individuals with Disabilities or Chronic Illness	System Avoidance • overwhelmed by service complexity • navigating health crises alone	Needs: relational stability, accessible support Opportunity: Healing-oriented calm spaces with stable helpers & stewards
Chronically Unhoused Individuals	Community Fragmentation • strong peer bonds but weak institutional ties • lack of stability	Needs: restorative practices, shared ownership Opportunity: Low-barrier co-stewardship roles that build trust and dignity



INTERVENTION DIRECTION COMMUNITY CO-OP GARDEN



SMALL, LOCAL, OPEN
& CONNECTED.



SHARED RECIPROCITY
& COLLECTIVE
RHYTHMS.



BUILD RELATIONAL
INFRASTRUCTURE.

RESEARCH PROCESS

FOCUS

Understanding how older adults experiencing housing uncertainty navigate isolation, disconnection, and unmet relational needs. Identify opportunities for care rooted in community and their daily environments.

GOAL + PURPOSE

Discover the emotional, social & environmental conditions that shape older adults’ sense of belonging, stability, and connection. Understand how small, place-based practices might support relational healing and resilience.

RESEARCH QUESTION

How might community-based, small-scale interventions support and engage emotional, relational & care needs of older adults living in housing uncertainty in Los Angeles?

PARTICIPATION + CONTEXT

- Older adults in housing uncertainty/instability
- Local community members, mutual aid volunteers, gardeners, neighborhood orgs.
- Environments: community gardens, senior centers, libraries, food banks, public spaces.

SCOPE + ASSUMPTIONS

- Research focus
- Relational care, not structural policy reform.
- Goal
- Explore meaningful small-scale interventions, not solve homelessness.
- Focus
- Reflect a slice of older adults’ experiences, not the whole.
- Emotional & Cultural factors:
- (jeong) shape how care is perceived & received.
- Research
- Iterative, reframing the problem as findings emerge.

METHODS

- Cultural probes
- Journey mapping
- Contextual inquiry
- Participant interviews
- Co-creation activities (collage, sketches, journal)

TIMELINE

- Phase 1
- Recruitment, contextual inquiry
- Phase 2
- Cultural probes & interviews, synthesis of emotional/relational themes
- Phase 3
- Co-creation activities, insight generation, reframing intervention direction

EXPECTED OUTCOMES

- Deeper understanding of care flows & fragmentation in older adults.
- Identify relational barriers and community resources.
- Visualize care flow maps, emotional journey patterns & opportunities.
- Refined prototype/intervention that supports community-led care practices.

ETHICAL CONSIDERATIONS

- Trauma-informed perspective
- Create safety, Provide anonymity & Preserve dignity
- Relational lens & systems-informed
- Consent-forward
- Checkpoint practices for emotional fatigue

A bouquet of orange and purple flowers is centered on a dark blue background. The orange flowers are in the foreground, and the purple flowers are behind them. The text "THANK YOU" is written in white, serif, all-caps font across the middle of the image.

THANK YOU